



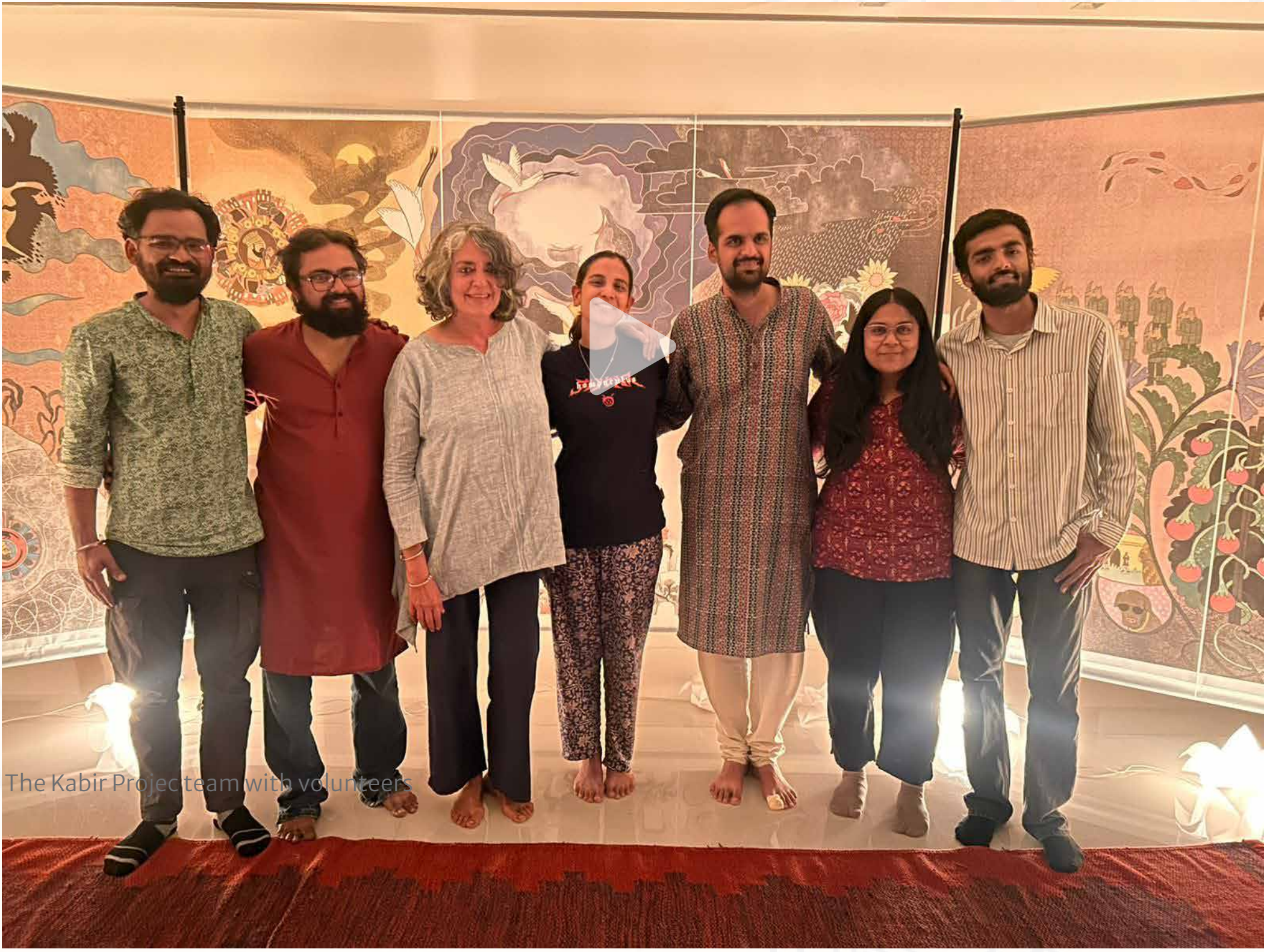
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Introduction to Ajab Shahar

Often Kabir and the mystics will invite us to a wondrous city (ajab shahar), a crazy land (deewaana des), utterly beyond borders, where everything thrives in an interconnected web of oneness. Inspired by that call, we have created here such a digital city of wonder, where singers, poems and songs from far flung regions, different languages and vividly distinct styles come and jostle together. What they share in common though, is the evocation of a truth beyond boundaries.

Wandering through this city you will hear many voices – from Pakistan in the west to Bengal in the east – singing, reflecting and expressing the wisdom of Bhakti, Sufi and Baul poets from in and around India. This is a digital dive into a vibrant oral tradition that keeps alive through song, the words of mystics and poets now long gone, such as Kabir, Meera, Ravidas, Bulleh Shah, Shah Latif, Lalon Fakir and so many others. The city has 3 main gateways – Songs, Poems and Reflections – but you could also wander through other pathways, such as People, Films, Radio or continue to read more about us, and what else we do on this page.

We are a small team bringing together our skills in filmmaking, design, writing, translation, singing and art to a shared passion and inspiration – the poetry of the mystics. We form the **Kabir Project**, which was seeded in 2002 at the Srishti Institute of Art, Design & Technology in Bangalore, India.



The Kabir Project team with volunteers

Inspired by Satsang

‘Sat-sang’ means to be in the ‘company of truth’. In many villages of rural India and neighbouring countries, people gather to participate in such satsangs (mehfils or samas in the Sufi context) – sessions of singing and deep listening to the songs of these poets. As the night progresses, listeners blend into the collective sound by singing or clapping along or playing cymbals. Perhaps the energy of a powerful satsang allows us to disengage from our particular and located selves. Our selves expand to include many others. Our identities dissolve ...[more](#)

Research and Curation

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Ethics of Use

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ABOUT **KABIR PROJECT**



About

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Kabir Project

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The Kabir Project team with volunteers



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Introduction to Kabir Project

The Kabir Project consists of many journeys inspired by Bhakti, Sufi, and Baul poems and songs as they flow in the rural folk traditions. Spanning over two decades, our inspirations in the wisdom of these poems has taken the shape of several FILMS, BOOKS, the AJAB SHAHAR web archive, an innovative schools curriculum SHABAD SHAALA, rural yatras, urban FESTIVALS & MORE. Inspired by the call of Kabir, the 15th century north Indian mystic poet, our journeys inquire into the spiritual and socio-political resonances of mystic poetry. The true spirit of our work lies in the taana-baana (warp & weft) of social networks and friendships built over two decades between the singers, scholars, activists, artists, students, and the larger public through our work which continues to expand in new and surprising directions.

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Current core team

Shabnam Virmani, Director
Smriti Chanchani, Senior Lead – Art & Design
Shreeparna Mitra, Shabad Shaala Coordination & Project Assistance
Shubhangi Bansal, Lead – Video & Sound Design
Anisha Baid, Lead – Research & Archiving
Kartikay Khetarpal, Lead – Creative Pedagogies
Alafiya Hasan, Lead – Game Design & Illustration
Psalm Paul, Production & Technical Manager
Hrishikesh Jha – Web Support



The Kabir Projec team with volunteers



The Kabir Project team with volunteers

Past Collaborators

Vipul Rikhi, Writing & Co–Creation
Prashant Parvatneni, Writing & Pedagogy

Project Assistance

Neha Rajan
Namrata Karthik
Namrata Ratnam

Poetry Insights

Prahlad Tipanya
Abdullah Hussain Turk
Parvathy Baul
& many other



Web Development

Thought Works, Bangalore
Langoor, Bangalore

Video Editing

Aarthi Parthasarathy
Radha Mahendru
Piyush Kashyap
Sharanya Gautam
Shruti Kulkarni

Camera

Smriti Chanchani
Aarthi Parthasarathy
Shabnam Virmani

Pedagogy Initiatives

Vishakha Chanchani

Past Donors

Ford Foundation
WIPRO Applying Thought in Schools
Raza Foundation
Kavita Chandna
Aroon Raman



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Films

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Journeys with Kabir

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Had Anhad I Lost My Heart To Nizam's Glance

The story highlights the gulshan-e-na-afreeda (the Uncreated Garden) that Shah Inayat spoke of, to evoke his utopian vision of a world in which the human spirit was not driven by fear, mistrust, oppression and exploitation, but rather was guided by a non-egoic spirit of connection and love.



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Ajab Mulakaatein

'Ajab Mulakaatein' was an attempt by the Kabir Project during the lockdown to meet with friends in wondrous ways despite the odds. Stumbling through virtual roadblocks, breaching borders, and creating new digital intimacies over Zoom, we connected with diverse folk singers and created 4 films that delved into the poetry of Shah Latif, Meerabai and others. The impulse of this series was to outreach and fundraise during the pandemic to support the livelihoods of folk singers and musicians ...[more](#)



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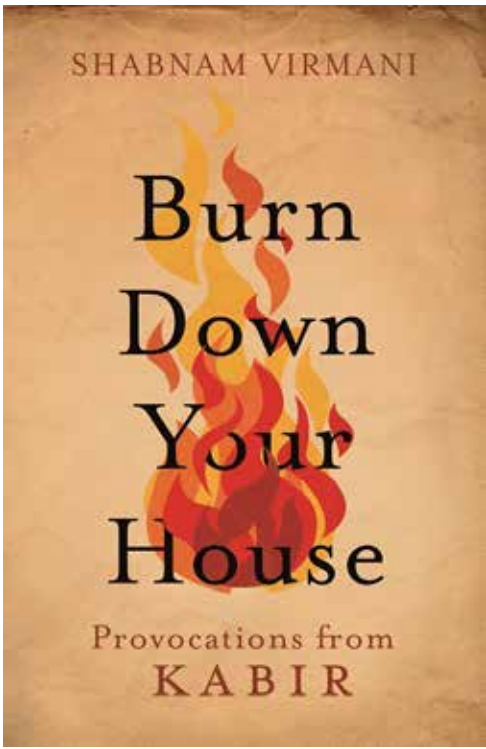
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Books

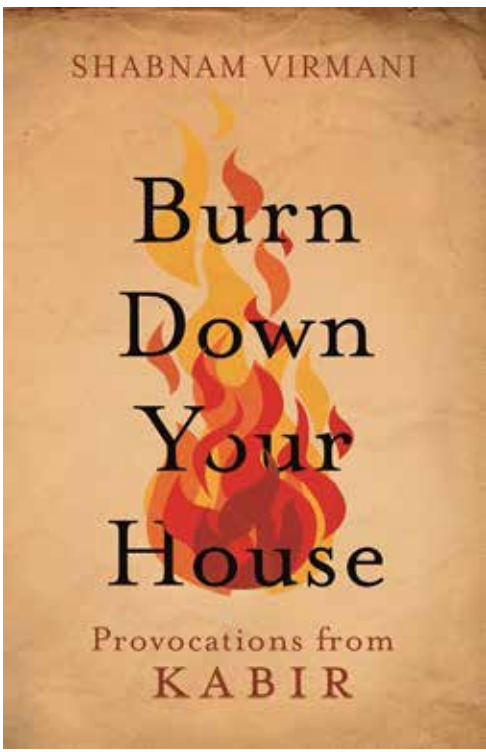
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Burn Down Your House *Provocations from Kabir*

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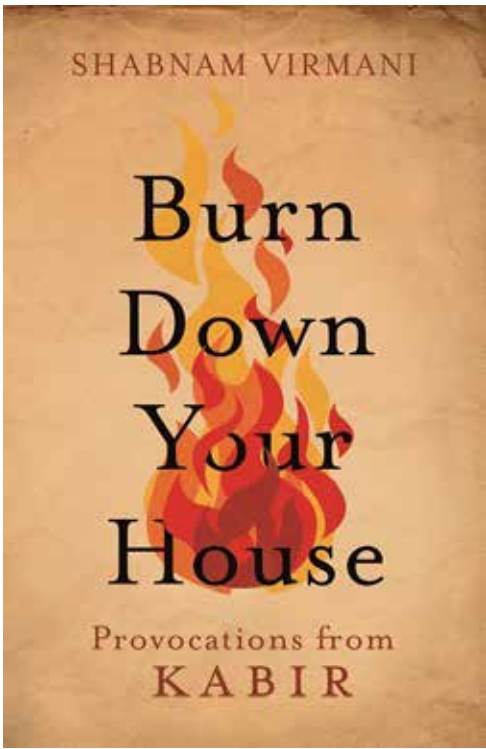
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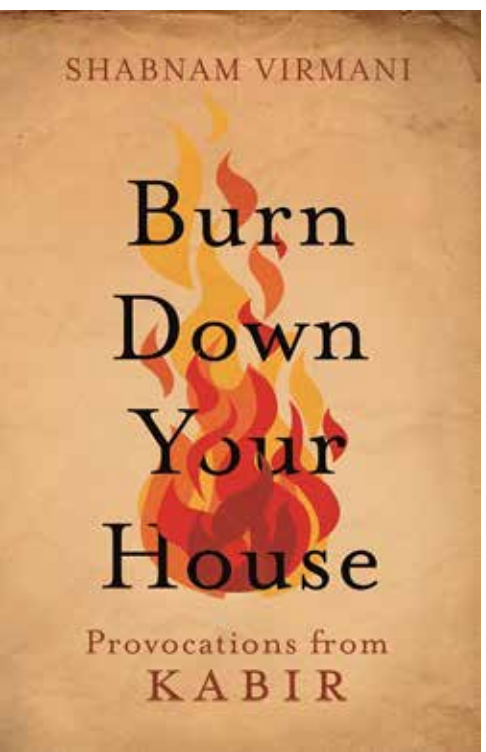
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